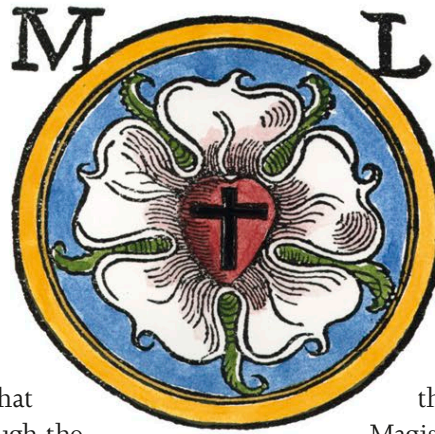


However, as war spread across Europe from 1618, enthusiasm for the order faded: one Rosicrucian tract even maintained that the brethren had moved “to the East.”

Rosicrucian occult revival

The optimistic Rosicrucian view that the world could be reformed through the application of arcane knowledge lost much of its appeal in the face of the Enlightenment, which, from the late 17th century, championed the use of modern science to achieve the same goals. Yet, in Germany a belief in the power of alchemy and Kabbalah persisted and in 1710, Samuel Richter, a Protestant pastor from Silesia, published a tract on the “Order of the Golden and Rosy Cross.” In it he described a new order, headed by an *Imperator* (Emperor), in which each of the brethren possessed a piece of the Philosopher’s Stone, the ultimate objective of alchemy (see pp.148–151).

These new Rosicrucians prospered. They became a secret lodge-based order, with a complex belief system and formal ceremonies in which would-be initiates had to answer a catechism of 35 questions in front of senior members seated at a table bearing a seven-branched candlestick. The nine degrees of



◀ Possibility of Lutheran link

The superficial resemblance of Protestant reformer Martin Luther’s seal (with a cross on a rose) to that of the Rosicrucians led some to speculate on a link between the two.

the order, starting with the Junior, then the Theoreticus, right up to Magister and Magus, each had access to a higher level of Rosicrucian secret knowledge, including how to transmute base matter into gold. For these neo-Rosicrucians, the alchemical change was not literal; rather, it was a symbolic transformation to a more spiritual plane.

Over time Rosicrucianism merged in part with similar secret societies including Freemasonry. It came into conflict with others, such as the Illuminati, which rejected the Rosicrucian devotion to alchemy. The revival of interest in the occult in the 19th century gave the Rosicrucian movement a fresh impetus. New orders were founded, including American branches such as the Rosicrucian Fellowship in Seattle in 1909 and The Ancient and Mystical Order Rosæ Crucis (AMORC) in New York in 1915. Both are still in existence today, admitting both female and male adult members.

IN CONTEXT

Imagining the ideal society

Narrative fictions that portrayed idealized societies became popular after the 1516 publication of English lawyer Thomas More’s *Utopia*. Fellow English philosopher Francis Bacon’s *New Atlantis* (1627), for instance, advocated rule by scientific experts. Many on the fringes of Rosicrucianism followed suit; the *Christianopolis* of Rosicrucian author Johann Valentin Andreae envisioned an ideal community on the island of Caphar Salama in the Indian Ocean. His imaginary reformed society was to be based on principles of individual piety, educational reform—the young drilled at boarding schools in mathematics and grammar from the age of six—and improving the inhabitants’ lives through scientific research.

Christianopolis: in his 1619 book, Johann Valentin Andreae gave much attention to the ordered and regular architecture of his ideal city.

